

ber of wooden boxes covered with industrial “no-slip” black-rubber matting. We all fought over the new boxes like tigers foraging for their cubs—our clerks. They needed to be kept happy. Turns out this was the least of our problems.

Like a Broadway theater, there was the “stage”—in our case, a high platform on which the specialists stood, looking across a chasm at the hordes of traders who were stationed atop a series of graduated tiers. In between, in the orchestra section, was a long passageway, ostensibly reserved for the waves of brokers who, during trading hours, moved in and out of the pit like spawning salmon. At least that was the way it was supposed to work, on paper. It never did. Chaos is not the sort of thing that lends itself to space allocation.

One thing that went wrong almost from the start was that the carpenters were designing this thing from blueprints instead of from observation. Had they bothered to see us in action, understood human greed, they’d have seen instantly that what mattered more than unobstructed vision—sight lines between traders and specialists—was (a) the proximity between the two groups, and (b) the need to be in voice contact with the specialists, to catch the hand signals, eye movements, and so forth. The problem was that the higher the traders and specialists were placed, the greater the distance. The communications gap became a chasm in which a lot of hand-to-hand combat took place. To keep the brokers from being overrun by the surge of frenzied traders, it became necessary to install a long metal railing, similar to the one found in every zoo around the polar bear cages. Actually, the analogy isn’t that farfetched. Before the railing was built, the poor brokers found themselves quite literally bulldozed up the other side of the pit by a swarm of angry traders, pinning us specialists against the makeshift wall behind us, and leaving us no choice but to use our feet to violently shove these bodies back down. There were days it looked like that famous castle-siege scene in any one of half-a-dozen Hollywood epics. Thanks to all those discarded ketchup packets, we even had the “bloodstains,” to show our battle worthiness.